Lesson 35: Late Adulthood: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 10.1: Discussion; 10.2: Listening-Population Pyramids- Powerful Predictors of the Future; 10.3: Reading-Introduction to Physical Development in Late Adulthood; 16.8: Chapter 8 (audio transcript).

In this lesson

You will think about long life, watch a TED-Ed lesson about population pyramids, and read two short texts about the "graying" (aging) of the population in the United States and around the world. You will learn how demographers describe a population and predict its future, and the language academic texts use for predictions. This prepares you for the simple future in Lesson 36 and for reading statistics in your psychology course.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a population pyramid shows and what its shape predicts.
- Answer detail questions about a short academic video and a text full of statistics.
- Recognize the language of predictions: will, be projected to, be expected to, it's projected that.
- Describe the "graying" of the population in the United States and in other countries.
- Discuss the factors that contribute to living a longer life.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
population PYR·a·mid	a graph of a country's population by age group, with females on one side and males on the other	Such a population pyramid can be a powerful predictor of future population trends.
de·MOG·ra·pher	a scientist who studies populations	One of the ways that demographers represent the internal distribution of a population is the population pyramid.
de·mo·GRAPH·ic	about a population (its size, ages, origins)	The year 2030 marks an important demographic turning point in U.S. history.
re·pro·DUC·tive years	the ages when people usually have children (15-44 in the video)	As today's children reach their reproductive years …
life ex·PEC·tan·cy	how many years people live on average	Countries … typically see an increase in life expectancy.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
birth rate / death rate	how many people are born / die in a year, compared with the size of the population	Both birth and death rates are low.
in·dus·tri·al·i·ZA·tion	the change from a farming economy to one with factories and industry	Countries that have only recently begun the process of industrialization ...
baby boomers	people born in the baby boom (a time when many babies were born) after World War II	By 2030, all baby boomers will be older than age 65.
median age	the middle age: half the people are younger and half are older	The median age of Americans is going up.
natural increase	births minus deaths	The population will naturally grow very slowly, leaving net international migration to overtake natural increase.
net international mi·GRA·tion	people who move into a country minus people who move out	Net international migration is projected to overtake natural increase in 2030 as the primary driver of population growth.
pro·JECT·ed to	predicted (from data) to	The 2030s are projected to be a transformative decade for the U.S. population.
offset	reduce the effect of something by acting against it	A rising number of deaths will increasingly offset how much births are able to contribute to population growth.

Rules and explanations

How a population pyramid works (from the video)

- Each bar shows the population numbers for a five-year age group, from 0-4 up to 100 and up. Females are on one side, males on the other.
- The groups: pre-reproductive (0-14), reproductive (15-44) and post-reproductive (45 and up).
- The shape predicts the future:

Country	Where most people are	Prediction
Rwanda	in the youngest age groups, at the bottom	fast growth: the population is almost certain to double within the next few decades
Canada	around the middle of the graph	the population will grow more slowly
Japan	in the post-reproductive years	the population will begin to decline

- These three pyramids show three stages of a demographic transition, as a country moves from a pre-industrial society to an industrial or post-industrial economy. Early in industrialization, life expectancy goes up and child mortality goes down, while birth rates stay the same: a population

boom. Later, birth rates fall (more education and opportunities for women, a move from rural to urban living). In advanced stages, birth and death rates are both low, and the population is stable or even begins to decline.

- A pyramid is also a record of the past: Russia's shows World War II, China's shows the one child policy, and the United States' shows the baby boom after World War II.

The language of predictions

Texts about populations make many predictions. Notice these forms; you will study will and be going to in Lesson 36.

Form	Example from the video or the reading
will + base verb	The number will grow rapidly in the coming years.
won't (will not) + base verb	But this similarity won't last long.
by + a future time, + will	By 2030, all baby boomers will be older than age 65.
be projected to + base verb	Japan ... is projected to retain (keep) this position through at least 2050.
be expected to + base verb	The population is expected to grow at a slower pace.
it's projected that + clause	By 2035, it's projected that there will be 76.7 million people under the age of 18.
be almost certain to + base verb	The total population is almost certain to double.

- "By 2030" means "not later than 2030".
- "Is projected to" and "is expected to" tell the reader that the prediction comes from data, here the U.S. Census Bureau's National Population Projections. They are useful in academic writing when you report what researchers predict.

Questions with "not"

Listening question 4 and reading question 2 ask what is NOT given or NOT projected. Check every option against the video or the text. The answer is the option that the source does not support.

Practice

Discussion (10.1). Answer the questions based on your experience and opinion. Write 3 to 5 sentences for each. Then follow the second idea in "Speak with your tutor" to reply to two "classmates".

1. How old is the oldest person you know?
2. What factors do you believe contribute to living a longer life?

Exercise 1. Listening comprehension. Watch "Population Pyramids: Powerful Predictors of the Future" (see Watch online) first, without the transcript. Answer the questions. Then watch again. Read the transcript at the end of the lesson material only after you have answered.

1. According to the Population Reference Bureau's "2013 World Population Data Sheet", 271 are born every minute, and 106 die every minute. That's a global net population increase of 165 per minute. This lesson was published on May 5th. What's the estimated global population increase exactly one week later (May 12th)? a) Approximately 10 million b) 20,739 c) 1,155 d) 1,663,200
2. Factors that can alter the trend represented by a population pyramid include: a) industrialization b) natural disasters c) education of women d) all of the above
3. As a country slows in population growth, its pyramid shape will a) become wider at the base and narrower at the top b) be inverted c) become more rectangular d) bulge in the middle
4. What does a Population Pyramid not give you information about? a) birth rates b) actual number of people c) life expectancy d) death rates
5. Which continent would have the fastest growth pyramids? a) Africa b) Asia c) North America d) South America
6. In an advanced stage of industrialization, a country will exhibit which set of characteristics? a) Low birth and death rates, stable population, good living conditions, long life expectancy. b) High birth and death rates, stable population, poor living condition, short life expectancy. c) High birth rate and low death rate, growing population, good living conditions, long life expectancy. d) High birth and death rates, stable population, harsh living conditions, short life expectancy.

Exercise 2. Reading comprehension. Read "'Graying' of America" and "'Graying' Around the World" in the lesson material. Then answer.

1. "Graying of America" refers to American's hair turning gray earlier than in other countries. a) True b) False
2. What is not a projected change in the 2030s in America? a) The older population will increase significantly. b) More people will immigrate to the US than are born in the US. c) The population will grow quicker. d) The race and ethnicity of the population will become more diverse.
3. Which statement explains the pace of population growth in America? a) The births will be much higher, but deaths will also be higher. b) The population is getting older, and people aren't having as many children. c) Many people are emigrating from the United States
4. Where is the majority of the "oldest countries" today? a) Asia b) Latin America c) Europe d) The Middle East

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the two discussion questions, then ask me follow-up questions about my answers. Correct my verb tenses."
- "Play two classmates. Write a short post from each about the discussion questions. I will reply to each one: I will point out a similarity or a difference, ask a clarifying question, or give my opinion."
- "I will explain what a population pyramid shows and what the pyramids of Rwanda, Canada and Japan predict. Ask me questions and correct my future forms."

- "Ask me five questions about the reading '"Graying" of America'. I will answer with will, is projected to and is expected to."
- "I will describe how the population of my country will change by 2050. Correct my grammar and ask me which factors will cause the change."

Read aloud

- Russia, with the largest territory in the world, has roughly the same total population as Nigeria, a country 1/16 (one-sixteenth) its size.
- But this similarity won't last long.
- Such a population PYR·a·mid can be a powerful predictor of future pop·u·LA·tion trends.
- By 2030 (twenty thirty), all baby boomers will be older than age 65 (sixty-five).
- The population is expected to grow at a slower pace, age considerably and become more racially and ethnically diverse.
- Japan, however, is currently the oldest nation in the world and is projected to retain this position through at least 2050 (twenty fifty).

Watch online

- TED-Ed lesson by Kim Preshoff, "Population Pyramids: Powerful Predictors of the Future" (watch before you read the transcript): https://ed.ted.com/lessons/population-pyramids-powerful-predictors-of-the-future-kim-preshoff
- The original text the reading comes from, "Introduction to Physical Development in Late Adulthood" (for more reading): https://courses.lumenlearning.com/wmopen-lifespandevelopment/chapter/physical-development-in-late-adulthood/

Answer key

Discussion (example answer)

1. The oldest person I know is my grandfather. He is 91 years old, and he still walks to the market every morning.
2. I believe that several factors contribute to living a longer life. The first is a healthy lifestyle: eating well, staying active and not smoking. Good medical care is also important. Finally, close family and friends keep older people busy and happy, and this may help them live longer.

Exercise 1

1. d) 1,663,200 (book). 165 per minute × 60 minutes × 24 hours × 7 days = 1,663,200.
2. d) all of the above (book). The video names industrialization and education and opportunities for women; it also shows that events such as a war can change a pyramid.
3. c) become more rectangular (book). Like Canada's pyramid: fewer young people, so the bars become more equal.
4. c) life expectancy (book). The pyramid shows the population numbers for each age group.
5. a) Africa (book). Rwanda, the video's fast-growing country, is in Africa.
6. a) (book). "Countries in advanced stages of industrialization reach a point where both birth and death rates are low, and the population remains stable or even begins to decline."

Exercise 2

1. b) False (book). The term means that the population is "becoming more dominated by older people": the median age is going up.
2. c) The population will grow quicker. (book) The text says that it "is expected to grow at a slower pace". Careful: option b is not exactly true either. Migration will overtake natural increase (births minus deaths), not births: births will still be "nearly four times larger" than net migration. The book means b as a true change, so c is the answer.
3. a) (book). "A rising number of deaths will increasingly offset how much births are able to contribute to population growth."
4. c) Europe (book). "Of the world's 25 oldest countries, 22 are in Europe."

My notes